

In the Grandmother's Hut

Every morning, Peter returned with his goats. Heidi eagerly joined them as they headed to the pasture. Heidi found herself growing stronger and getting a sun-kissed tan as the days passed.

When autumn arrived, the mountain air became crisp and windy. Sometimes, Grandfather would look out at the fierce wind and say, "You need to stay inside today, Heidi. The wind might sweep you down into the valley with just one big puff!"

On those windy days, Peter felt sad without Heidi. He missed her company. Without her, the goats hardly followed him. Also, he missed out on the yummy big lunches he enjoyed when Heidi was around.

On days when she stayed home, Heidi didn't mind at all. She loved to watch her grandfather working with his tools, sawing and hammering away. One of her favorite activities was watching him make small, round cheeses and churn butter with his strong arms. And when the wind roared through



the fir trees, Heidi would run outside. The magical sounds of the branches swaying thrilled her.

As it got colder, Heidi had to wear her shoes, stockings, and a warm dress to keep cozy. Peter would blow into his hands to warm them as he arrived each morning. He shivered in the chilly air. Eventually, it became too snowy even for Peter to visit. One morning, Heidi watched from the window as snow kept piling up, higher and higher. After a time, it nearly covered their windows completely.

The snowfall continued for several days. Heidi wondered if it would bury their little cottage. Finally, the snow stopped. Grandfather had to shovel away the heaps of snow from their doorstep and around the windows. Later that day, Heidi and her grandfather sat near the cozy fireplace. They felt safe and warm inside their snug mountain home.

When Heidi was by the fire, noisy footsteps sounded outside. Then the door burst open. It was Peter, coming to visit Heidi. He mumbled a "Good-evening" and walked up to the fire. His face was all bright. Heidi laughed because his clothes were dripping water everywhere. He was melting like a snowman in the warm room.

Grandfather asked Peter how school was going. Heidi, curious as always, bombarded Peter with lots of questions. Peter wasn't much of a talker, so he found it hard to keep up with Heidi's rapid questions. But at least it gave him time to dry off.

While they talked, Grandfather was watching with a twinkle in his eye. Finally, he joked with Peter, "You've been



under fire, General. Now it's time to refuel!" And with that, Grandfather made a hearty supper. Peter ate hungrily.

As it grew dark, Peter knew it was time to go. But before he left, he told Heidi, "I'll be back next Sunday. My grandmother says she would love to meet you."

Heidi was excited about this. She told Grandfather that they needed to visit Grandmother first thing the next morning. Four days later, when the sun was shining and the snow was crackling, Heidi pleaded with Grandfather to let her go visit Grandmother.

Grandfather agreed, fetched her warm cover, and led her outside. Everything was silent. The snow-covered trees sparkled in the sunlight. They looked as if they were sprinkled with silver and gold. Heidi ran around shouting, "Grandfather, come quick! Look at the trees!"

Grandfather came out with a big sled, wrapped Heidi warmly, and set her on it. Holding Heidi securely, she and Grandfather shot through the magical winter landscape. Heidi shouted with excitement. She felt like she was flying!

Grandfather stopped the sled in front of Peter's hut. "Go on in," he told Heidi. "When it gets dark, start on your way home." After unwrapping her from her warm coverings, Grandfather left with the sled.

Heidi opened the door to a small, dark kitchen. She walked into a narrow room where Peter's mother was sewing his coat. Heidi recognized it right away. In the corner of the room, there was an old woman. This was Peter's grandmother. Heidi walked up to her and cheerfully said, "Hello,



Heidi is delighted by the magical winter landscape



Grandmother! I'm here now, did I make you wait long?"

Peter's grandmother, who was blind, felt around for Heidi's hand. "Are you the little girl who lives with Uncle up on the mountain? Is your name Heidi?"

"Yes," Heidi replied. "Grandfather just brought me down in the sled."

"How is that possible?" Peter's grandmother cried. "Your hands are as warm as toast! Brigida, did Uncle really come down with the child?"

Peter's mom, Brigida, was surprised and unsure if Heidi had come with her grandfather. But Heidi insisted that they had sled down together, wrapped up warmly. This surprised everyone. They hadn't expected Heidi to stay with her grumpy grandfather for long.

Grandmother said, "Brigida, tell me what she looks like."

"She has her mother's long, thin arms and legs. She has black eyes and curly hair like her father. She looks a bit like both of them."

While the women were talking, Heidi had been taking in everything. Then she said, "Grandmother, look at the shutter over there. It's hanging loose. If Grandfather were here, he would fix it. It'll break the windowpane the way it's flapping!"

"What a sweet child you are," said Grandmother tenderly. "I can hear shutters banging, but I can't see it, Child. This cottage rattles and creaks, and when the wind blows, it comes in through every crack. Someday the whole house will crum-



ble and fall on top of us. If only Peter knew how to fix it! We have no one else."

"Grandmother, can't you see the shutter?" asked Heidi.

"Child, I can't see anything," said the old woman sadly.

"Can you see when I open the shutter to let in the light?"

"No, no, not even then. Nobody can ever show me the light again."

Heidi was frightened. "But what about when you go out into the snow, where everything is bright? Come with me, Grandmother, I'll show you!" She took the old woman by the hand and tried to lead her outside.

"Just let me stay here, child," said the old woman. "Everything is dark for me. My poor eyes can't see anything."

"But Grandmother, what about in the summer? You can't see when the sun shines down on the mountains to say good-night?"

"No, child, I can never see the fiery mountains again. I have to live in darkness, always."

Heidi burst out crying now. "Can't anyone make it light for you? Is there nobody who can do it, Grandmother? Nobody?"

Grandmother tried to comfort Heidi. She said, "Heidi, let me tell you something. People who can't see love to listen to friendly words. Sit down beside me and tell me all about yourself. Talk to me about your grandfather. It's been a long time since I have heard anything about him. I used to know him very well."

Wiping her tears, Heidi felt a spark of hope. She prom-



ised to talk to her grandfather about making things better for Grandmother. She thought he could fix the house and maybe help Grandmother see the light.

Full of energy, Heidi began to describe her life with her grandfather. Listening carefully, Peter's mother and grandmother would mutter to each other, "Did you hear that? Do you hear what she says about Uncle?"

As Heidi was telling her story, Peter barged in with a loud thump on the door. He was so happy to see Heidi that his eyes grew huge, and he smiled broadly. Heidi greeted him with a cheerful, "Good evening, Peter!"

Peter's grandmother was surprised that it was already time for him to come home. "Time flies," she said. "How's your reading coming along?"

Peter shrugged and said, "Just the same."

"Oh dear, I was hoping you'd gotten better," sighed his grandmother. "You're nearly twelve years old!"

Heidi, curious, asked, "Why do you want him to read better?" Grandmother explained that there was an old prayer book with lovely songs on a shelf. She had nearly forgotten the songs because no one reads them to her anymore. She hoped Peter could read them to her someday. But she was losing hope that he would ever learn to read well.

It was getting late. Peter's mother lit a lamp. Seeing this, Heidi quickly said her goodbyes. "Good-night. I have to go since it's getting dark."

But Grandmother was worried. "Wait, Child, don't go up alone! Peter, go with her and make sure she's safe and warm."



Heidi describes her life to Grandmother



Does Heidi have a shawl?"

Heidi, already out the door, shouted back, "I don't have one, but I'll be fine." She started running so fast that Peter struggled to keep up.

From the house, Grandmother anxiously called, "Brigida, hurry! Run after her with a warm shawl. It's cold tonight!"

As Heidi and Peter climbed up the path, they met the old man coming down. He was happy Heidi was on time and wrapped her in her cover. He then carried Heidi up the hill in his arms. Brigida arrived just in time to see this and went back to tell Grandmother what she saw. "Thank goodness," the old woman said happily. "I hope she comes back. She makes me feel so much better! She's so kind and talks so nicely." All evening, the old woman kept thinking, "I hope he lets her come back! Now I have something to look forward to, thank God!"

As soon as Heidi and her grandfather were inside their cottage, Heidi was bursting to talk. "Grandfather, we need to take some nails and a hammer to Grandmother's house tomorrow. A shutter is loose, and many other things are falling apart. Everything makes noise in her house."

"Really? And who said we must fix it?" her grandfather asked.

"Nobody told me, but I know," Heidi answered. "Poor Grandmother said she was worried the house might fall apart. Also, Grandfather, she can't see well. Can you help make her house brighter? It must be so scary to be in the dark and have no one to help you! Oh, please, Grandfather,



can you fix it for her? I know you can."

Heidi was holding onto her grandfather and looking up at him with hopeful eyes. Finally, he looked down and said, "Okay, child, we'll make sure the house won't shake anymore. We can do it tomorrow."

Heidi was so happy to hear this that she started dancing around the room, shouting, "We're going to fix it tomorrow! We can do it tomorrow!"

The next day, Grandfather took Heidi down as he had promised. After Heidi had greeted Grandmother, he started checking the house. Grandmother was so happy to see Heidi again. She had been working at a spinning wheel making wool thread. She stopped her work and exclaimed, "Here is the child again! She has come back!"

Heidi grabbed Grandmother's hands. She sat on a stool by her feet, starting to chat. Soon, loud banging noises came from outside. Grandmother got scared, accidentally almost knocking over her spinning wheel. She screamed, "Oh, God!"

"Grandmother, don't be frightened," said the child. She put her arms around the old woman. "Grandfather is just fixing everything for you."

When Brigida went outside, she saw Heidi's grandfather putting a new beam in the wall. She thanked him for his help. Grandmother wanted to thank him too. But Grandfather said gruffly that he didn't need any thanks.

He worked hard all afternoon, even climbing on the roof to fix it. Eventually, he had to stop because he ran out of nails and it was getting dark. Heidi was ready to go home.



Grandfather tucked her snugly in his arms, and they left.

As the winter passed, Grandmother felt happier. Her days were brighter with Heidi's visits. Every morning, Grandmother eagerly waited to hear Heidi's footsteps. When Heidi arrived, she would share stories and make Grandmother smile and laugh.

Before Heidi's arrival in her life, Grandmother used to wish for days to end quickly. But now, with Heidi's visits, she felt joy. She wondered how the time passed so quickly. Even Brigida agreed because Heidi had also won her heart.

Grandmother often hoped that Heidi would stay with them. "And I hope that your grandfather stays as kind as he has become lately."

"Is Heidi doing alright, Brigida?" was a question Grandmother asked often. The answer was always comforting. Heidi grew to love the old woman deeply. Whenever the weather was nice that winter, she visited her every day. When Heidi remembered that Grandmother could not see, she felt very sad. But knowing her visits made the old woman happy brought her some comfort.

Grandfather fixed up the cottage well. He carried down heavy loads of timber to use. Grandmother said that the cottage was no longer noisy. She said she slept better that winter than she had in many years, all thanks to the kindness of Grandfather.



Grandfather works hard all afternoon

